

CHAPTER 8 — Taken

"It started on an ordinary Tuesday," Zoe said. "That's the part people would get wrong afterwards. I hadn't run away. I hadn't arranged to meet anyone. I was just walking home."

Elias did not interrupt.

He had learned that much already. Zoe came forward at her own pace. Pushing only sent her back into silence.

"I was still in my school uniform," she said. "Helen had asked me to get milk."

That morning, Helen had called up the stairs three times before Zoe answered.

"You'll miss the bus."

"I'm not getting the bus."

"You said that yesterday."

"I didn't get it yesterday either."

"You still missed it."

Zoe had appeared at the top of the stairs with one shoe on, her tie hanging loose and her hair only half tied back.

Helen stood below holding a travel mug in one hand and Zoe's lunch in the other.

"You look organised," she said.

"I am organised."

"You're wearing one shoe."

"I know where the other one is."

"Where?"

Zoe looked back towards her bedroom.

Helen raised an eyebrow.

"Nearly know," Zoe corrected.

It had been that kind of morning.

Nothing dramatic. Nothing that felt important enough to remember.

Brian had already left for work. The radio was on in the kitchen. Helen had burnt one piece of toast and scraped the black edge over the sink before spreading jam across what remained. Zoe ate it standing up while trying to fasten her tie.

At school, Jackie took one look at her and said, "You forgot—"

"My science book."

"I was going to say your dignity."

"Left that at home too."

Jackie grinned and handed over the book Zoe had lent her the week before.

They spent lunch sitting on the low wall behind the sports hall, sharing a packet of crisps and arguing about whether the substitute maths teacher wore the same shirt every day or owned five identical ones.

"Five," Jackie said.

"One."

"Five would be stranger."

"One would smell worse."

Jackie considered that.

"Fair."

The final bell went at half past three. Jackie walked with Zoe as far as the crossing where their routes separated.

"Message me when you get home," Jackie said.

"You message me."

"You always reply first."

"That makes no sense."

"It does in my head."

"That's the problem."

Jackie started backing away, smiling.

"Later."

"Later."

Zoe watched her reach the opposite pavement before turning towards home.

By five, the school day had already become ordinary enough to forget.

Helen was in the kitchen, opening cupboards with increasing irritation.

"We're out of milk."

"You bought some yesterday."

"I thought I bought some yesterday."

"You bought orange juice."

Helen looked into the fridge as though the milk might have concealed itself behind the vegetables.

"Corner shop?"

Zoe was still wearing most of her uniform. She had thrown her blazer over a chair and changed her shoes, but the white shirt, dark skirt and black tights remained. She took the money Helen held out.

"Chocolate?"

"Milk."

"That wasn't my question."

"You have your own money."

"That also wasn't my question."

Helen sighed and added a pound coin to her palm.

"Straight there and back."

"It's four streets."

"Things can happen in four streets."

Helen said it lightly. The kind of warning adults gave because they believed saying it counted as protection.

Zoe rolled her eyes and left.

The corner shop was exactly where it had always been.

The same faded advertisements covered the window. The same bell gave the same tired jangle above the door. The man behind the counter was watching football on a small television beneath the cigarettes and barely looked up when Zoe placed a bottle of milk and a chocolate bar in front of him.

Outside, the evening was warm enough that she put her earphones in and carried her blazer folded over one arm.

Four streets.

She had walked them so often that her body knew the route without instruction: left at the boarded-up florist, across beside the post box, past the garden with the stone dog, then straight until her front door came into view.

Nothing about the street had changed.

A van pulled alongside her before she registered that it was slowing.

White. No company name. Dirt around the rear wheel arch.

The side door opened.

A hand closed over her mouth before she could produce more than a muffled gasp. Another arm locked around her waist and lifted her backwards.

The bottle struck the pavement and split.

Milk ran white along the kerb.

That was the last thing she saw of the street before someone pulled her into the dark.

She had no chance to fight. By the time her body understood what was happening, the door had slammed shut and the van was already moving.

Someone held her wrists.

A man told her to stay quiet.

Zoe kicked once and struck metal. Pain travelled up her heel. The grip on her wrists tightened until her fingers went numb.

“Stop,” the man said.

She stopped kicking.

Not because she agreed.

Because she needed to breathe, and because the van was turning hard enough to throw her against the side, and because there were at least two people inside with her and she could not see either of their faces properly.

So she counted instead.

Left turn.

Long straight road.

Roundabout.

Two speed bumps close together.

A sharper right.

The air inside smelled of diesel, damp fabric and something sweet that had spilled into the floor mat.

She listened for traffic. Tried to judge speed. Tried to remember how long they travelled.

Fear kept breaking the count apart.

She began again each time.

"You hadn't been contacted beforehand," Elias said.

It was not phrased as an accusation.

Zoe looked at him through the mirror.

"No."

"Nobody was waiting for you?"

"No."

"You hadn't arranged to meet anyone?"

"I was buying milk."

"I know."

"You asked."

"I needed the answer from you."

She looked towards the side window.

"I stayed awake," she said. "The whole way."

Elias gave a small nod.

"What do you remember?"

"Not enough to find it from the route. Enough to know they didn't take me far."

"How?"

"Traffic. The roads. We stopped twice, but not for long. And when they opened the door again, it was still light."

Elias waited.

Zoe continued.

The van stopped inside a garage.

She knew because the sound changed first. The engine noise came back from close walls. Then a metal door rattled down behind them, shutting out the street before the side door opened.

The men walked her through an internal door into a house.

No blindfold.

No hood.

They did not think she needed one.

The house sat on a quiet residential road with a trimmed lawn and a child's bicycle lying on its side in the front garden. Zoe saw it through the narrow window beside the front door as they passed. One wheel turned slightly in the breeze.

The curtains were drawn in every room she could see, upstairs and down.

Inside smelled of carpet cleaner and something colder underneath it that she could not name.

They walked her through the front hall.

A locked glass cabinet stood against one wall. Rows of folders filled the shelves inside, each labelled with a number instead of a name.

Nobody tried to block her view.

The cabinet was locked. The adults had already decided that meant whatever it contained was safe from her.

Further along, a study door stood open by several inches. Zoe saw a safe set into the wall, its keypad glowing faint green, before one of the men reached across and pulled the door shut.

A woman met them in the kitchen.

Mid-thirties. Pleasant face. Hair tied back. The kind of ordinary that made the room feel less safe rather than more.

She poured Zoe a glass of water she had not requested and placed it on the table as though this were a normal visit to a normal house.

"You'll be processed tomorrow," the woman said, in the same tone she might have used for *The bus comes at nine*.

"Processed for what?"

The woman did not answer.

She smiled briefly—the way adults smiled at children they had already decided not to explain anything to—then told one of the men to take Zoe upstairs.

The bedroom contained a single bed, a wardrobe and a window too high for her to reach without standing on something.

The wardrobe was empty.

The window opened no more than an inch.

The lock was on the outside of the door.

Zoe checked all three before she sat on the bed.

She barely slept.

She lay in a room that was not hers and listened to footsteps pass in the corridor. Pipes clicked inside the wall. A door opened somewhere below and closed again.

Whenever she shut her eyes, she saw the bottle striking the pavement.

Milk running along the kerb.

She wondered whether Helen had gone looking for her yet.

Whether Jackie had sent the message she had promised to send.

Whether anyone had found the chocolate bar crushed beside the broken bottle.

And whether *processed* had ever meant anything good for anyone.

Elias took the next junction more slowly than necessary, letting the silence remain hers.

"You didn't know Cain's name then?"

"Soon enough."

Her voice had gone quiet.

"That's the next part."

Elias merged back into the traffic.

He checked the mirror once. Not because Mac had asked him to collect her. Not because the job required it.

Because Zoe was there.

"Keep going when you're ready," he said. "I'm listening."

Zoe nodded and, after a moment, continued.